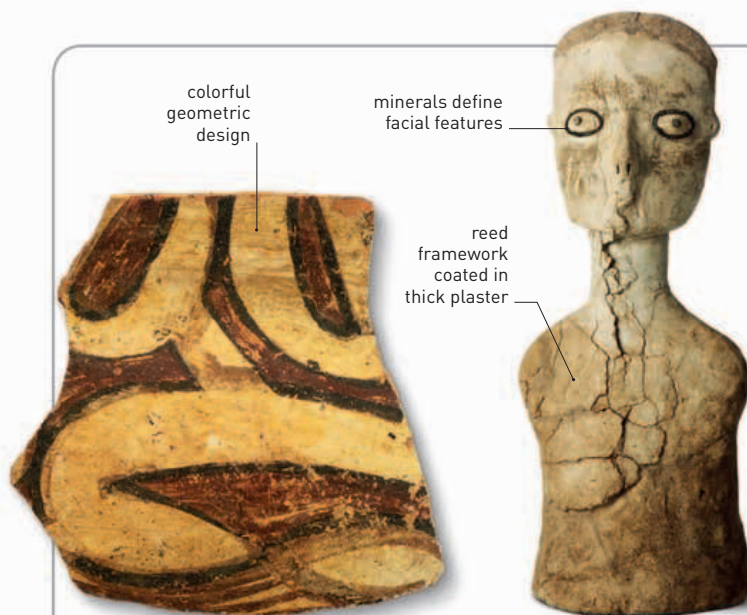




Pottery shard
4000 BCE • ROMANIA

Different cultures can be identified by their unique ways of decorating objects—this shard is typical of the Cucuteni-Tripolye culture.

minerals define facial features

reed framework coated in thick plaster

Human figurine
6750–6500 BCE • JORDAN

This large statue from Ain Ghazal is one of several from sites in the Near East that may have represented ancestors or gods.

hole for cord

geometric, abstract pattern



Schist plaque
4000 BCE • PORTUGAL

It is unclear what Neolithic engraved plaques, like this one from Alentejo, symbolized, but they seem to have been made for burial with the dead.



finely detailed engraving

Engraved bone
13,000–8000 BCE • FRANCE

Paleolithic artists often carved as well as painted their depictions of animals, as with this scene of a bison being chased, from Laugerie-Basse.

PREHISTORIC PEOPLES

EARLY HUMANS ARE DEFINED BY THE RAW MATERIALS THEY USED TO FASHION TOOLS, WEAPONS, AND ORNAMENTS

Prehistory is traditionally divided into the Stone, Bronze, and Iron ages, but many other kinds of raw materials such as wood, hide, and plant fibers were also used in early technologies. Little evidence of these survives.

In addition to being functional aids to survival and subsistence, the objects made by prehistoric peoples would also have been important in their social lives. Different groups develop their own ways of manufacturing and decorating objects, and distinctive designs may become badges of identity or status symbols. The trade and exchange of objects is another vital way in which individuals and groups establish social relationships and hierarchies.

carefully sharpened tip

carved antler setting

leather or sinew binding

flint head set into wooden sleeve

reproduced wooden handle



Oldowan tool
2.6–1.7 MYA • AFRICA

The earliest stone tools were simple, sharp-edged flakes of stone, made by striking a stone cobble with a hard “hammerstone.”

scars where blades chipped from core

remains of flaked cobble



Blades and core
100,000 BCE ONWARDS • WIDESPREAD

Early modern humans produced uniform, narrow blades that would have been fitted to wooden and antler handles or held in the hand, as tools for many different purposes.

long, thin blade



thick base is easy to hold

Flint hand-axe
200,000 BCE • UK

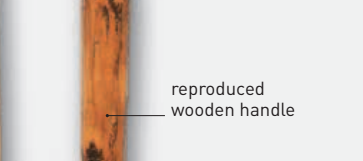
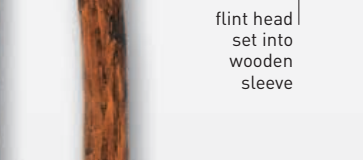
Hand-axes, such as this one from Swanscombe, were skillfully made and used for a wide range of activities, including woodworking and butchery.



Antler harpoon
8000 BCE • UK

This harpoon head is attached to a long handle for spearing fish—a key source of food when sea levels rose as the last Ice Age ended.

barbed head made from antler



These Mesolithic adzes were used for digging up edible roots or cutting wood in the forests that spread across Europe after the last Ice Age ended.